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Democracy Dies in Darkness

MONDAY, OCTOBER 20, 2025 • \$4

Israeli strikes hit Gaza days into truce

Dozens killed after IDF says it responded to alleged Hamas violation

BY SHIRA RUBIN,
LIOR SOROKA,
SIHAM SHAMALAKH
AND HEIDI LEVINE

TEL AVIV — The Israeli military launched a wave of strikes across the Gaza Strip on Sunday, killing about 44 people, according to local hospitals, after Israel accused Hamas of violating a nine-day-old truce by attacking its troops behind the ceasefire line.

In a statement, the Israel Defense Forces said that militants fired at troops in Rafah in southern Gaza, including with an anti-tank missile. Later, it announced that two soldiers had been killed.

Hamas's armed wing, the Izzedine al-Qassam Brigades, said it was unaware of any clashes in Rafah, where the IDF maintains control, and that it had long ago lost contact with any fighters there.

The escalation Sunday was the most serious challenge yet to an already tenuous ceasefire backed by the United States. Israel and Hamas signed on to the first phase of the deal, which required Israel to partially withdraw troops, allow the free flow of humanitarian aid and release a specific number of Palestinian prisoners and detainees.

Hamas agreed to release the remaining hostages it abducted in the attacks on Oct. 7, 2023, including the bodies of those who either died that day or were killed in captivity. So far, the group has freed 20 living hostages and the remains of 12 others. Hamas has said it will take time to find and exhume the bodies of 16 others without specialized equipment.

SEE ISRAEL ON A12

Disaster at Dallas



KEVIN JAIRAJ/IMAGN IMAGES

The Commanders' Jayden Daniels fumbles on this hit by the Cowboys' Shemar James in the third quarter in Arlington, Texas. The second-year quarterback left the game with a hamstring injury, the most nightmarish moment of an ugly 44-22 defeat that dropped Washington below .500 for the first time this season. **Story, C1**

Downballot scandals roil Virginia governor's race

BY GREGORY S. SCHNEIDER

RICHMOND — The Virginia governor's race was supposed to be the marquee contest of 2025, a historic showdown between two women who national Democrats and Republicans alike hope can rally their parties into next year's congressional midterms.

But two downballot contests keep stealing the limelight in unpredictable ways.

An October surprise involving the emergence of violently worded text messages sent by Demo-

cratic attorney general hopeful become GOP's focal point

cratic attorney general nominee Jay Jones in 2022 has become the focal point of Republicans' closing arguments in the final weeks before Election Day on Nov. 4 — even in the governor's race.

"Everything is about Jay Jones. Period," Mark Harris, the political

consultant for GOP gubernatorial nominee Winsome Earle-Sears, told reporters after his candidate debated Democratic nominee Abigail Spanberger on Oct. 9 in Norfolk.

In April, it was Republicans dealing with a scandal, when Gov. Glenn Youngkin (R) pressed GOP lieutenant governor nominee John Reid to drop out over lewd photos of men posted to a social media account that Youngkin said was Reid's.

Reid, who is openly gay, disavowed the account and stayed in

the race, but has struggled to raise money, while some conservatives have continued to distance themselves from him. The controversy flared anew this month when Democrats charged that some of the images were reposted from accounts that promoted Nazi porn. Reid, a Richmond talk radio host, is running against Democratic state Sen. Ghazala F. Hashmi (Richmond).

"It's odd that ... these two downballot races are affecting the governor's race," said Rich

SEE VIRGINIA ON A7

Rubio pledge was key to pact

MS-13 INFORMANTS
SEALED PRISON DEAL

Some in DOJ wary about
renewing on promises

BY JOHN HUDSON,
JEREMY ROEBUCK
AND SAMANTHA SCHMIDT

In the days before the Trump administration deported hundreds of Venezuelan immigrants to a notorious prison in El Salvador, the president of that country demanded something for himself: the return of nine MS-13 gang leaders in U.S. custody.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio, in a March 13 phone call with Salvadoran President Nayib Bukele, promised the request would be fulfilled, according to officials familiar with the conversation. But there was one obstacle: Some of the MS-13 members Bukele wanted were "informants" under the protection of the U.S. government, Rubio told him.

To deport them to El Salvador, Attorney General Pam Bondi would need to terminate the Justice Department's arrangements with those men, Rubio said. He assured Bukele that Bondi would complete that process and Washington would hand over the MS-13 leaders.

Rubio's extraordinary pledge illustrates the extent to which the Trump administration was willing to meet Bukele's demands as it negotiated what would become one of the signature agreements of President Donald Trump's early months in office. While the outlines of the quid pro quo have been public for months, the Trump administration's willingness to renege on secret arrangements

SEE RUBIO ON A10

As hotel stays plunge, luxe bookings are booming

BY ABHA BHATTARAI

Andrew Satkowiak expected a vacation slowdown this year.

But his clients are traveling to Miami and New York, Europe and the Caribbean, sending inquiries soaring by 15 percent. A typical hotel stay for such travelers now ranges from \$1,500 to \$2,500 per night, up from about \$900 before the pandemic, according to Satkowiak, executive vice president at the Luxury Travel Agency in Nashville.

"Sometimes when I quote people, I'm like, 'Oh my God, \$3,500 a night? They're never going to take it,'" he said. "But they're not fazed. They'll just say, 'Oh yeah, that's fine.'"

While many Americans have pulled back on hotel spending, so much so that the sector is facing some of its biggest declines since the pandemic, the wealthiest continue to spend on luxury stays. They are benefiting from the run-up in stock markets and higher home values and shelling out for high-end hotels as part of elaborate vacations.

That pattern is playing out across the economy. The housing market is stalled, but sales of million-dollar homes remain

SEE HOTELS ON A18



DIMITAR DILKOFF/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

French police stand by an elevator used by robbers to enter the Louvre museum in Paris on Sunday.

In daylight heist, thieves target the Louvre

Stolen pieces included thousands of diamonds and many precious jewels

BY JENNIFER HASSAN,
LEO SANDS
AND SAMMY WESTFALL

Not long after Paris's Louvre museum opened its doors to visitors on Sunday, the thieves made their move. Using a mechanized furniture elevator attached to a truck, they forced their way through a window and into the

Apollo Gallery — home to the French crown jewels.

It took the robbers just seven minutes to execute their daytime heist, French Interior Minister Laurent Nuñez said. They used a grinder to cut through display cases, helping themselves to precious jewelry before making their escape on motorbikes.

Two high-security display cases

of Napoleon-era jewelry were targeted. The thieves took nine objects, one of which was recovered near the scene, Paris Prosecutor Laure Beccuau told local news. Together, the stolen pieces included thousands of diamonds and many precious jewels.

The pieces of jewelry stolen included a tiara, necklace and an

SEE LOUVRE ON A13

Defense press confronts new reality of Pentagon access

Outlets, barred from
entry, pivot to report
from outside building

BY SCOTT NOVER

When a throng of military journalists relinquished their credentials Wednesday after refusing to sign the Defense Department's new restrictive press policy, it ended more than 80 years of in-building coverage by major news organizations — including the New York Times, The Washington Post and CBS News, which reported live from the Pentagon on D-Day in 1944.

The Defense Department's new policy blocks any journalist from soliciting information the department has not authorized for release — even unclassified details.

With only 14 individuals agreeing to the rules, dozens of outlets are confronting a new reality: the challenges of covering the Defense Department from purely outside of its five-sided nerve center on the Potomac.

"Will it be a little tougher? Will it require a little more elbow grease? Perhaps," said Barbara Starr, a former CNN reporter who covered the Pentagon for more than 20 years. "But it's also the case that we have seen in the last couple of days, the Pentagon

press corps is continuing to get scoops."

The media policy is the latest press restriction imposed by Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, who has altered norms by rarely holding press briefings and requiring reporters to use Pentagon escorts to walk in certain parts of the building. The limitations represent a sharp departure from the twice-weekly briefings, free movement and dedicated in-building desk space that Pentagon reporters have traditionally been granted.

Media organizations say they are still deciding how to confront the new restrictions, which could include suing to regain access or strike down some of the Pentagon's requirements. Some publications said they are considering increasing foreign reporting to prepare for decreased material out of Washington. Because the Pentagon's new policy prohibits reporters from soliciting information the government has not authorized, some media experts say it might serve as a warning to would-be leakers about the consequences of talking to the press.

And while being blocked from the facilities will not prevent journalists from reporting, it will make it harder to land key details and scoops, veteran reporters said.

Starr, who left CNN in 2022 and is a senior fellow at the

SEE PENTAGON ON A4

IN THE NEWS

A traditionalist push The arrival of Pope Leo XIV has sparked a campaign in the Catholic Church to remove restrictions on the Latin Mass imposed by Pope Francis. **A12**

Costlier medication New U.S. trade policies have upended a work-around used by many Americans to import prescription drugs. **A9**

THE NATION **George Santos**, freed by President Donald Trump, now wants to reform U.S. prisons. **A2** **Hunting** will go forward in many national refuges during the government shutdown. **A5**

THE WORLD **The political turmoil** in France is putting E.U. initiatives at risk. **A11** **A French journalist** investigating a soccer star's death found himself facing terrorism charges in Algeria. **A13**

THE ECONOMY **Auto insurance rates** are rising across the country, but premiums can vary widely depending on your state. **A14** **Microsoft** is rolling out an AI feature that lets users talk to a Windows 11 PC the way they would interact with a smart speaker. **A14**

STYLE **Cameron Roh**, who makes videos in which he rates how people walk, has advice about sidewalk etiquette. **B1**

SPORTS **A sluggish start** by the Capitals resulted in a 4-3 loss to Vancouver and the end of a four-game winning streak. **C1**

THE REGION **A project** to add express toll lanes to more of the Capital Beltway is on hold for now. **C11**

HEALTH & SCIENCE **Heart disease** could be better treated by focusing on early detection, a growing number of cardiologists and public health experts say. **D1**

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